RESEARCH BRIEF • EVIDENCE CHECKED 7 OCTOBER 2026

Lebanon’s destruction 2006 · 2024 · 2026

Buildings, homes, land, infrastructure and satellite evidence

The clearest comparison: approximately 45,400 housing units were destroyed in the 2024 assessment, against an early estimate of 15,000 in 2006. In 2026, a later southern survey identifies 24,068 destroyed *buildings*—a different unit and a limited geographic area. [1] [5] [6] [9]

Measure	2006	2024 conflict	2026 evidence so far
Destroyed homes / units	~15,000 housing units; early estimate	45,400 housing units	No complete national total verified
All damaged homes / units	~30,000 homes damaged or destroyed	162,900 housing units, including destroyed	Southern survey: 80,599 modeled units affected; mixed use
Building counts	No comparable national count verified	63,962 affected, including possible damage; 23,389 destroyed or severely damaged	Southern survey: 24,068 destroyed; 52,284 with any assessed damage
Geography / dates	July–August 2006; contemporary estimates	Main national RDNA: 8 Oct 2023–20 Dec 2024	South: June imagery; Beirut: April; sector reports: August–September

Sources and definitions differ. Figures in a row are not automatically directly comparable. [1] [2] [6] [7] [9]

Read the units before the totals

A **building** may contain many apartments. A **housing unit** is a dwelling. **Affected** can include light or possible damage. A burned hectare measures land, while debris volume measures rubble. None is interchangeable.

Scope of this review

“20006” is interpreted as 2006. This is a broad review of public UN, World Bank, Lebanese research, humanitarian and satellite-investigation evidence—not a claim to have searched every web page. 2026 is incomplete: these are dated observations available by 7 October, not a final post-war census.

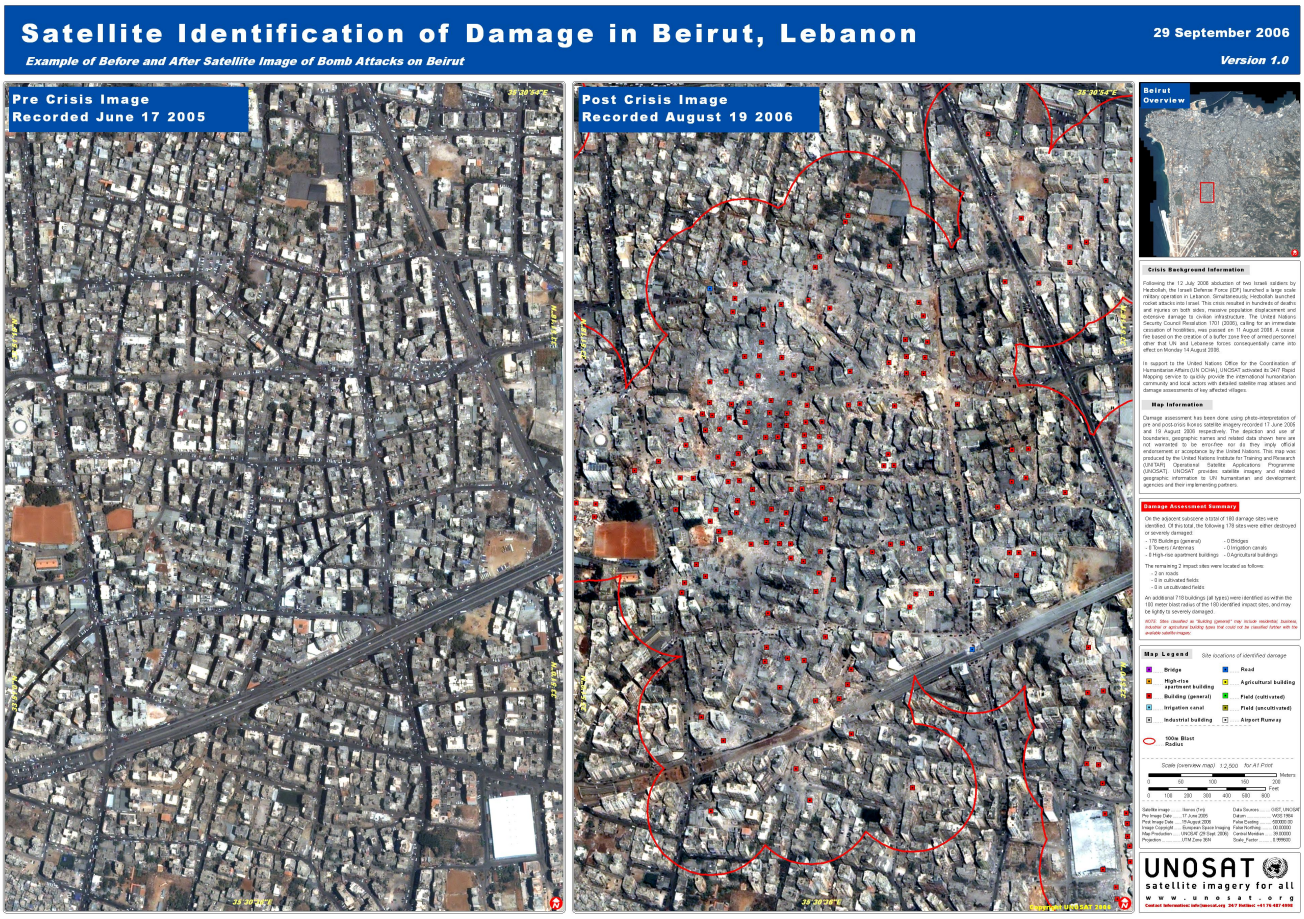
All monetary figures are US dollars at the source’s valuation date; they are not adjusted for inflation. Images are documentary source material, not generated illustrations.

2006: housing and major infrastructure

Indicator	Reported scale
Housing	~15,000 units destroyed initially; ~30,000 homes damaged or destroyed in the later August update
Transport	145 bridges / overpasses and about 600 km of roads damaged or destroyed
Other facilities	900 factories, markets, farms and other commercial buildings; 23 fuel stations
Combined infrastructure category	29 airports, ports, water / sewage facilities, dams and electrical plants—not 29 airports

Contemporary OCHA / Lebanese Higher Relief Council reporting; estimates were still evolving. [1] [2]

Beirut, before and after the 2006 war



UNOSAT map: imagery from 17 June 2005 and 19 August 2006. The mapped subscene identifies 178 severely damaged / destroyed buildings and two road impacts. The additional 718 buildings within a blast buffer are possible exposure, not confirmed damage. This is a local image analysis, not Lebanon's national total. [4]

The bridge and road figures describe a different pattern of infrastructure destruction from later wars. They do not establish a comparable national count of buildings.

2024: homes and buildings are different totals

Housing units, national RDNA	Count
Destroyed	45,400
Partially damaged	74,300
Lightly damaged	43,200
Total affected	162,900

About 10% of the pre-conflict housing stock. RDNA housing chapter, printed p. 42. [6]

Buildings affected, by governorate

Governorate	Affected buildings	Destroyed / severe
Nabatiyeh	31,451	14,409
South	17,842	6,965
Mount Lebanon	7,154	479
Bekaa	3,797	666
Baalbek–Hermel	3,676	864
Beirut	42	6
Total	63,962	23,389

ESCWA / UNDP, printed pp. 32–34. “Affected” includes moderate and possible damage. These estimates are separate from the World Bank housing-unit inventory. [7]

How to interpret the figures

The ESCWA / UNDP categories total 23,389 destroyed or severely damaged buildings, 11,576 moderately damaged and 28,997 possibly damaged. “63,962 buildings destroyed” would therefore be incorrect. Its 229,125 affected units include housing *and non-housing* uses. [7]

The published Mount Lebanon / Baabda severity subtotals do not fully reconcile with their affected-building totals. This brief retains the reported headline numbers and does not manufacture a corrected subtotal.

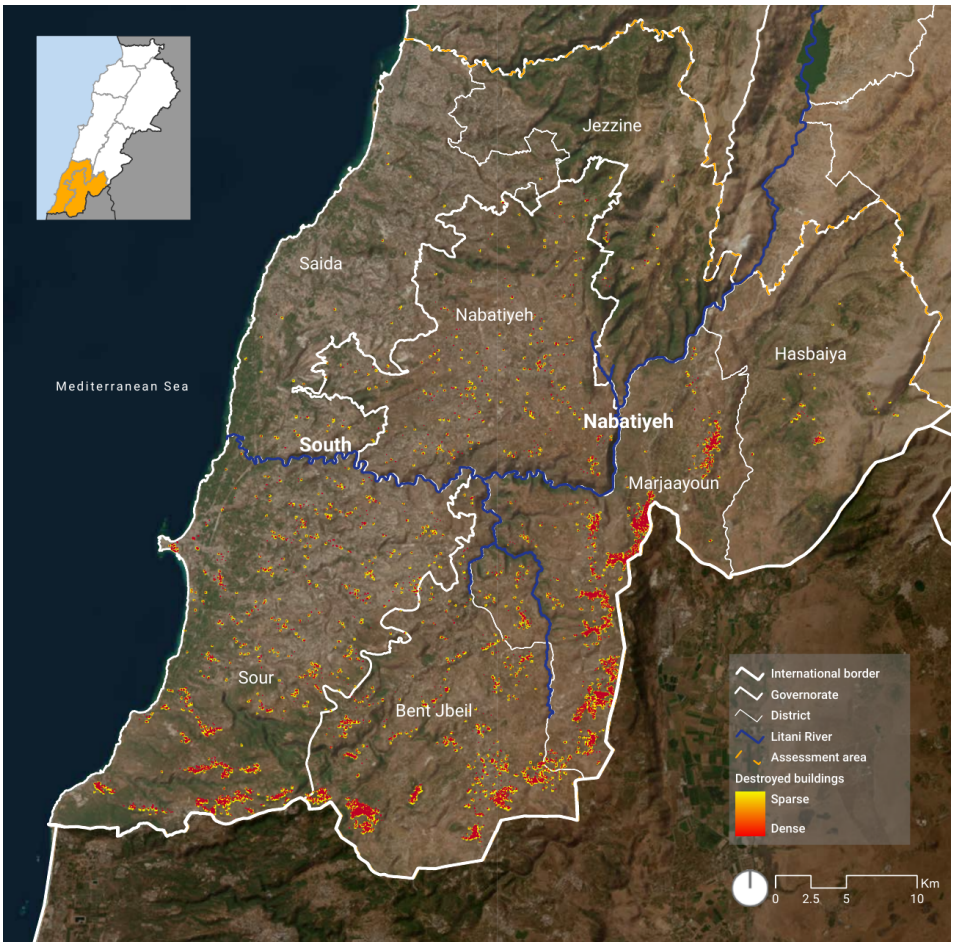
The 45,400-to-15,000 housing comparison suggests roughly three times as many destroyed dwellings in 2024 as in the early 2006 estimate. Differences in timing, definitions and assessment methods prevent treating that ratio as an exact measurement.

“Beirut” administrative totals exclude many southern suburbs, which are counted under Mount Lebanon.

Where destruction concentrated

UN-Habitat and university partners identified **18,507 totally or partially destroyed buildings** in South and Nabatiyeh governorates, using 3 December 2024 imagery. [8]

District	Buildings
Marjaayoun	7,577
Bent Jbeil	5,129
Sour / Tyre	4,551
Nabatiyeh	900
Hasbaiya	178
Saida	108
Jezzine	64
Total	18,507



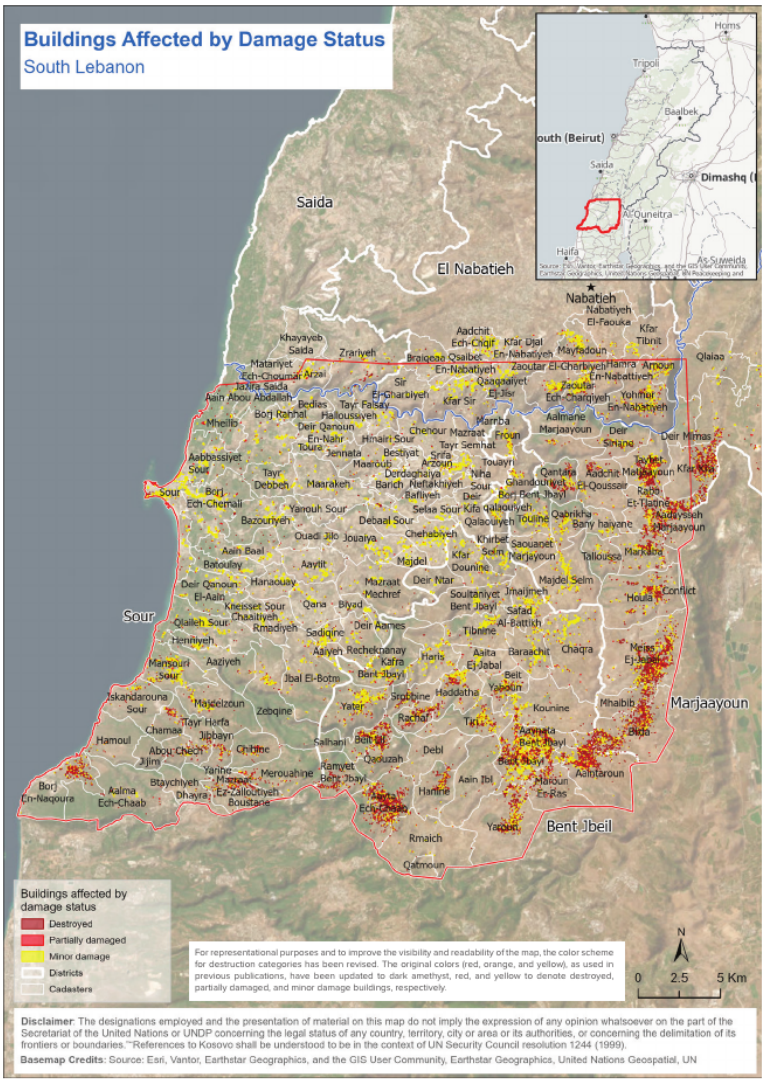
Original UN-Habitat / University of Balamand / USJ map, cropped from its first page with its legend retained. Red indicates denser mapped destruction; it is not a measured area of completely razed land. [8]

Examples: Meiss El Jabal 1,523; Kfar Kila 1,485; Aayta El Chaab 1,309; Khiyam 720; Houla 699. Counts include partial destruction. The 18,507 total represents 7.7% of 237,425 buildings in this study's stock. [8]

A large new layer of destruction

UNDP's July issue uses June 2026 imagery and an October 2025 baseline. It excludes buildings already identified as damaged in 2024. [9]

Assessed buildings	Destroyed	Partial	Minor	All affected
167,460	24,068	7,191	21,025	52,284



Most affected localities

Buildings with any assessed damage:

Locality	Affected
Bent Jbayl	2,712
Aaintaroun	2,528
Meiss Ej Jabal	2,507
Blida	1,495
Taybet Marjaayoun	1,426
Aaynata	1,285
Aayta Ech Chaab	1,276
Kfar Kila	1,233
Sour	867
Chaqra	864

These are **not** destroyed-only counts. Local percentages use the assessed stock after exclusions.

Map and counts: UNDP, issue 2. Main text dates imagery 16 June; workflow also references 20 June. Within the study: 20,568 destroyed buildings in Nabatiyeh governorate and 3,500 in South governorate. Modeled destroyed units: 36,139; these are not a census of occupied homes. [9]

Coverage limits

143 cadastres were fully covered and 20 partially covered. Cloud-obscured and pre-existing damaged buildings were excluded. This is a satellite-based estimate without comprehensive field validation. It is not a national October total.

The earlier April-imagery assessment counted 11,095 destroyed buildings. Do not add the two releases or attribute the entire difference to new damage: coverage and classification also changed. [10]

2026: Beirut and essential services

Beirut and Mount Lebanon

Building assessment	Reported result
Destroyed / partially damaged buildings	146 / 264
Separately documented targeted apartments	54
Destroyed / partially damaged housing units	3,168 / 4,437
Debris	648,942 m³
Estimated building damage	US$365 million

UNDP; February-to-14 April 2026 imagery, supplemented by records and field checks with CNRS-L. Counts concentrate in the southern suburbs, including Haret Hreik, Hadath and Chiyah. They do not cover all Lebanon. [11] [12]

Later evidence: schools, hospitals and water

Sector / observation date	What is documented	What it does not mean
Education • end August 2026	436 affected education facilities: 194 minor, 141 moderate, 64 severe, 37 destroyed	37 is included in 436. Survey covers 1,089 accessible facilities.
Health • 14 September 2026	17 hospitals damaged, including 3 closed; 21 supported primary-care centres closed	Closed does not necessarily mean structurally destroyed.
Water • 9 September 2026	MSF reports damage to wells, pumps, filtration, storage and pipes; Yater and Froun tanks beyond repair	Field evidence is not a nationwide infrastructure census.

Education: UNICEF. Health: WHO. Water: MSF. The observation dates differ. [16] [17] [18]

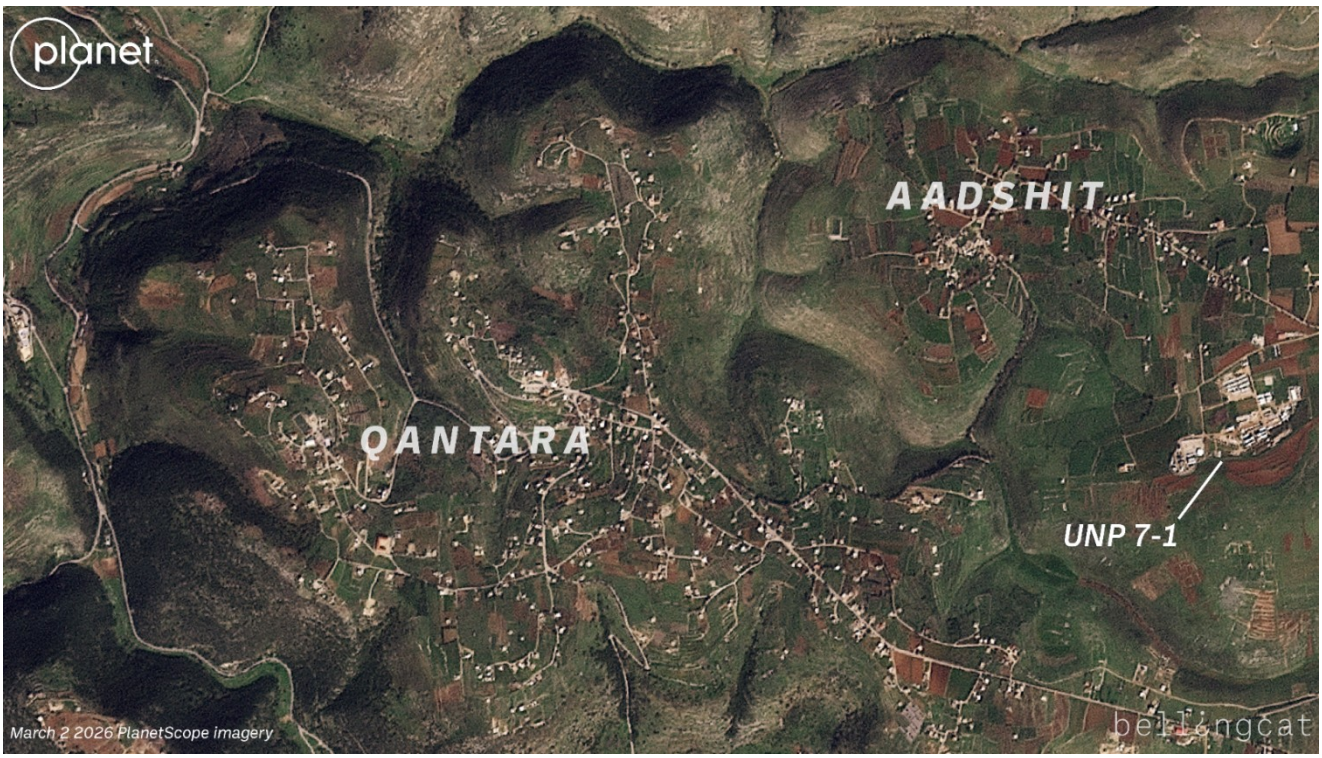
Why building counts understate the burden

An intact house can still be unusable when water, power, access roads or nearby services fail. A closed school used as a shelter is not automatically a destroyed school. Structural loss, service interruption and displacement require separate measurements.

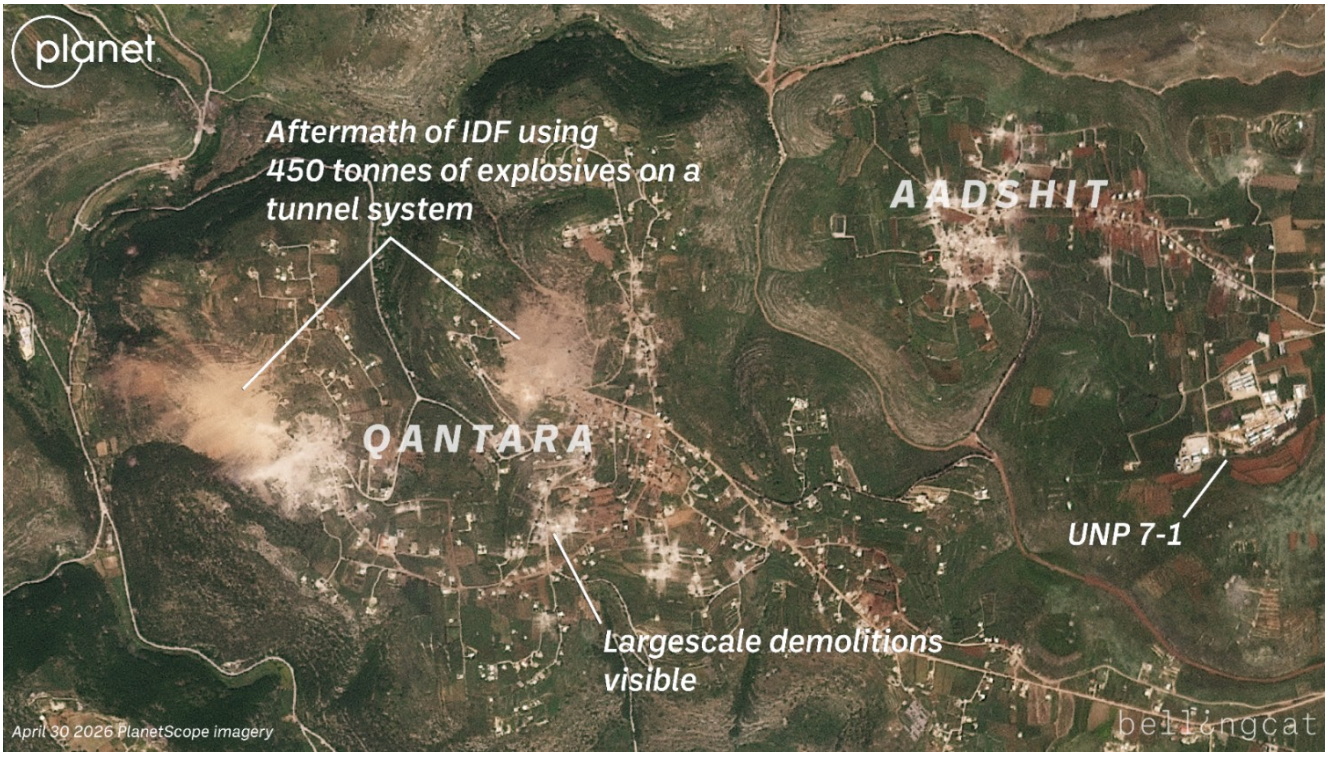
WHO records 215 attacks on healthcare since 2 March, with 135 deaths and 416 injuries in those attacks, as of 14 September. An attack count is not a count of distinct damaged facilities. [17]

Qantara and Aadshit, March–April 2026

Before • 2 March 2026



After • 30 April 2026



Planet imagery published by Bellingcat on 14 May 2026. Original publisher annotations are retained. Any annotated explosive quantity is a reported military claim, not something measured from the pixels. [13]

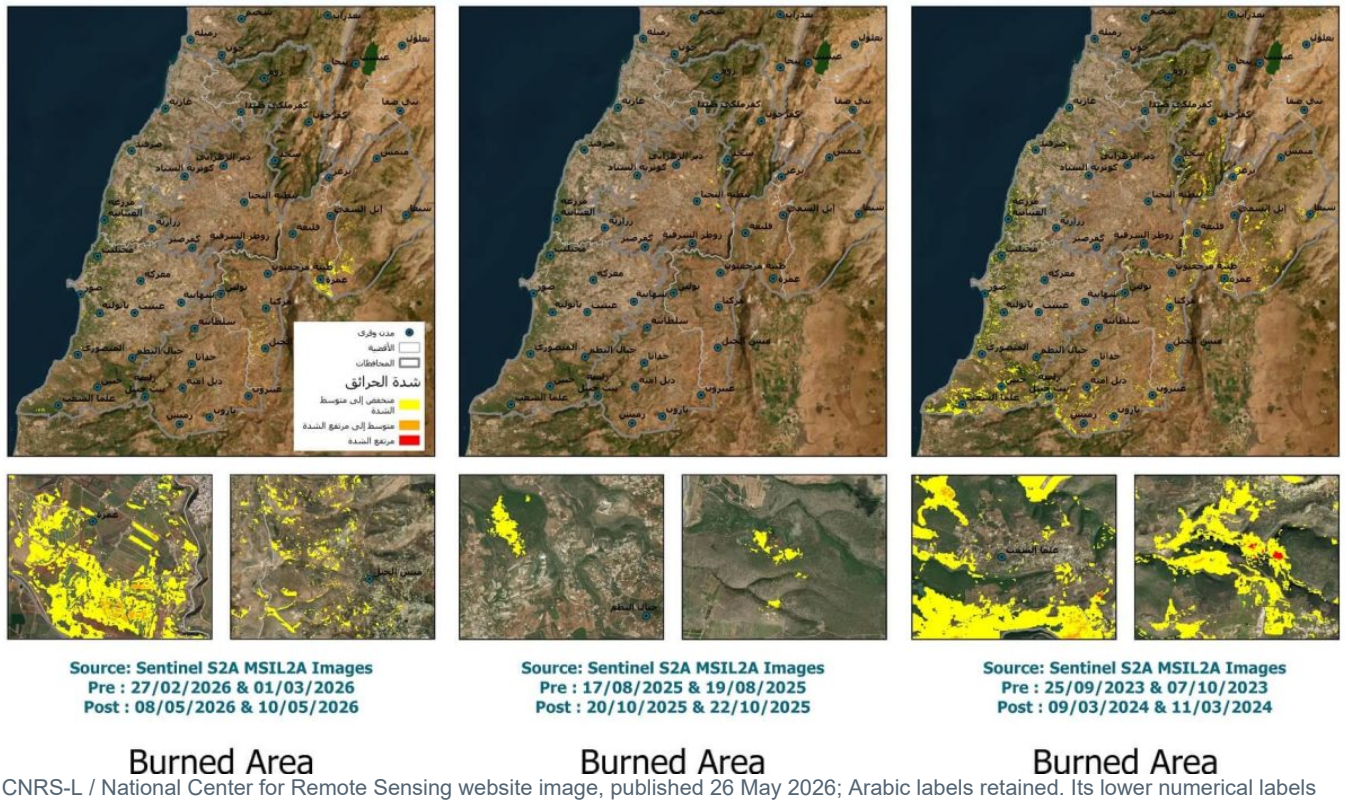
The pair illustrates extensive physical change at these locations; it does not establish a national building total. The interactive viewer compares broader imagery from 2 March and 8 May. [14]

How much land was destroyed?

No directly comparable nationwide “urban area destroyed” total in km² was verified for all three periods. Available land measures describe fires, vegetation, individual sites or assessment boundaries.

Measure and source scope	Reported area	Converted area
2006 forest affected by fire: alternative contemporary inventories	1,800–2,338 ha	18.00–23.38 km²
2023–2024 burned land: CNRS-L southern map	8,556 ha	85.56 km²
2024–2026 ceasefire interval: same map	160 ha	1.60 km²
Since 2 March 2026: map published 26 May	1,914 ha	19.14 km²

One hectare = 0.01 km². The 2006 estimate concerns forest; later map categories concern burned land. Coverage, dates and land classes differ. Do not interpret ratios as a comparison of urban destruction or add periods without checking overlap. [3] [15]



CNRS-L / National Center for Remote Sensing website image, published 26 May 2026; Arabic labels retained. Its lower numerical labels are cropped in the published web image; figures above come from the accompanying source text. [15]

Other environmental damage

The 2006 coastal oil spill affected about 150 km of shoreline. That is a linear coastal distance, not 150 km² of destroyed land. [19]

Evacuation zones, military control areas, municipal boundaries and the number of affected villages are also not measurements of physically destroyed land. A defensible urban-area total requires dated damage polygons, a stated severity threshold and deduplication.

Debris volumes and economic consequences

Assessment	Rubble volume	Estimated mass
2006, three principal regions	5.75 million m³	No comparable mass used here
2024, ESCWA / UNDP	12.01 million m³	20.29–27.02 million tonnes
2024, South + Nabatiyeh subset	6.19 million m³	10.47–13.93 million tonnes
2026, UNDP southern study	7.01 million m³	11.84–15.77 million tonnes
2026, Beirut + Mount Lebanon	0.649 million m³	1.10–1.46 million tonnes

Estimates are model-based and geographically overlapping within each year; the 2024 southern subset is not additional to the broader total. The World Bank separately estimates 16.9 million tonnes for 2024 using a different method. [3] [6] [7] [8] [9] [11]

2024 damage, losses and needs by sector

US$ million	Physical damage	Economic losses	Recovery needs
Agriculture / food	79	742	412
Commerce / industry / tourism	612	3,410	1,849
Education	151	414	554
Energy	98	209	147
Environment / debris	512	790	444
Health	208	700	409
Housing	4,580	363	6,252
Municipal / public services	41	192	76
Transport	198	173	302
Water / wastewater / irrigation	356	171	508
Total, source rounding	6,834	7,164	10,951

World Bank RDNA, printed p. 23. Totals may differ from sums of displayed rounded sector figures. [6]

Physical damage concerns assets; economic losses concern flows such as interrupted production. Recovery needs are a funding estimate. Do not add all three columns into a “destruction cost.”

2006 contemporary direct-damage estimates varied roughly from US$2.4 billion to US$3.6 billion. The 2026 southern study estimates US$3.05 billion in building damage, excluding minor damage and infrastructure; it is not a national reconstruction bill. [2] [3] [9]

Patterns, uncertainty and unresolved totals

Physical damage extends beyond residential buildings

2024 national RDNA indicators	Reported scale
Roads	930 km damaged: 216 destroyed, 714 partly damaged
Bridges	6 damaged
Education assets	59 destroyed; 299 partially damaged
Health assets	298 destroyed; 587 partially damaged

Health assets include pharmacies and other facilities: this is not 885 hospitals. RDNA printed pp. 32, 39 and 46. Asset inventories differ from the 2006 and 2026 sources. [6]

Geographic and cultural detail

CNRS-L counted 353 completely destroyed buildings in Beirut's southern suburbs for the 2023–2024 offensive. This is a local subset. UNESCO's March 2025 mission documented destruction of Baalbek's Manchieh heritage building and the entrance to Bustan el-Khan; this should not be described as destruction of the entire Roman complex. [22] [20]

Destruction continued across reporting boundaries

Amnesty's satellite investigation covers 1 October 2024–26 January 2025 and reports over 10,000 heavily damaged or destroyed structures in 24 municipalities. Because it crosses the ceasefire and overlaps other inventories, it is evidence of continued destruction rather than an extra total to add. [21]

What can be concluded

2024 caused substantially greater documented housing loss than the initial 2006 estimate. The 2026 evidence establishes extensive additional destruction, especially in the southern border belt. Bellingcat found heavy damage or flattening in 46 of 54 examined towns and villages within the reported "Yellow Line"; this does not mean 46 settlements were completely erased. [13]

What remains unmeasured on a common basis

A national 2026 building census through October; a consistent strict destroyed-only building total for every year; nationwide urban destruction polygons in km²; and the surviving unrepaired stock after repeated damage and reconstruction.

How this brief avoids double counting

Separate buildings from apartments; retain each source's damage classes; record image dates separately from publication dates; compare geographic coverage; and treat successive releases as revisions. A current cumulative total would require matching individual properties across years, including repairs and demolitions.

These limitations do not imply small damage. They define what the evidence can support without overstating precision.

Primary assessments and historical imagery

Numbered references in the text and the titles below are clickable. Page references elsewhere use the document's printed page numbers. Research cutoff: 7 October 2026.

[1] OCHA / UN, 16 August 2006: initial housing estimate

[2] OCHA / UN, 25 August 2006: housing and infrastructure

[3] World Bank, 2007: Economic Assessment of Environmental Degradation Due to July 2006 Hostilities

[4] UNOSAT: Beirut pre/post imagery, product 253

[5] World Bank, 7 March 2025: Lebanon recovery and reconstruction needs

[6] World Bank, 2025: Lebanon Rapid Damage and Needs Assessment (RDNA)

[7] ESCWA / UNDP, 2025: Socioeconomic Impacts of the Lebanon 2024 War

[8] UN-Habitat / University of Balamand / USJ, revised 22 January 2025: South and Nabatiyeh assessment

[9] UNDP, July 2026, issue 2: South Lebanon building-level factsheet

[10] UNDP, June 2026: earlier South Lebanon factsheet

[11] UNDP, June 2026: Beirut and Mount Lebanon factsheet

Image provenance

2006: UNOSAT product 253. 2024: UN-Habitat / University of Balamand / USJ map. 2026: UNDP southern assessment map; Planet satellite images as published by Bellingcat; CNRS-L burned-area map. Original captions, legends and dates are preserved or stated next to each image.

Later 2026 evidence and supplementary sources

[12] UNDP, 9 June 2026: Beirut and Mount Lebanon assessment announcement

[13] Bellingcat, 14 May 2026: satellite investigation of southern Lebanon

[14] Bellingcat: interactive March / May 2026 satellite comparison

[15] CNRS-L, 26 May 2026: fire severity and burned-area map

[16] UNICEF, September 2026: Attacks on Education (data through August)

[17] WHO, 15 September 2026: Middle East conflict situation report

[18] MSF, 9 September 2026: damage to southern Lebanon water infrastructure

[19] UN, 17 August 2006: coastal oil pollution

[20] UNESCO, 2025: Baalbek state of conservation

[21] Amnesty International, 26 August 2025: property destruction after the 2024 ceasefire

[22] CNRS-L: 2023–2024 offensive damage report

Research and interpretation

This brief prioritizes assessments with explicit geography, dates, damage classes and methods. Reporting from humanitarian organizations and satellite investigators fills gaps, but is not silently substituted for a national census. Where estimates differ, their scope or definition is explained rather than averaged.

Downloadable companion images

The accompanying 2006 Beirut satellite comparison, 2024 and 2026 southern damage maps, and March/April 2026 Qantara–Aadshit image pair allow closer inspection than a printed page. The Bellingcat interactive viewer [14] supplies a broader geographic comparison.